

HIGH SCHOOLS

Putting others first

The team is the name of the game for Rangers' Marci Spelich as point guard sacrifices to ensure Eastlake North victories

By MIKE PETTICA
PLAIN DEALER STAFF

Marci Spelich approaches life as a daughter as she approaches playing point guard in basketball.

She puts others before herself.

"I don't have to tell her to do the dishes, and if the house needs vacuumed, she does it," said Nancy Spelich, the mother of Eastlake North's splendid playmaker.

"Marci will help cut the grass for her Dad because she knows he's been working hard. She goes to church on her own. We don't have to tell her. When she talks about basketball, she always talks about the other kids."

Spelich's selflessness around the house is no surprise if you've seen her play basketball. A talented player in her own right, she seldom looks to score, sacrificing personal statistics to put the team first.

"Statistics don't really mean much as long as we win," said Spelich, a 5-6 senior. "All that matters is that we play hard and that we win. I don't care about my points at all."

Spelich's statistics are ordinary. She hit four 3-point shots for all of her 12 points in the Rangers' 93-39 season-opening victory over Brush, then scored two points in a 55-50 victory over Magnificat. North was ranked as high as 11th in national preseason polls.

Last season, Spelich averaged four points, five assists, four steals and four rebounds. But North, with no seniors, went 20-6 and advanced to a Division I regional championship game.

"There were many times last season in the tournament when we'd take another starter off the floor," North coach Bob Beutel said, "before we'd take Marci off the floor, because we'd feel more comfortable."

"She is about team. She runs the show for us."

Spelich plays a little like point guard K.C. Jones did for the Boston Celtics' dynasty of the 1950s and '60s. Jones never averaged in double figures scoring, but he did so much else.

North often breaks full-court pressure with a long pass by Spelich over the defense. "She has a John Elway arm," Beutel said.

Spelich is usually the "ghost" in the Rangers' "ghost defense." In the scheme, the Rangers virtually ignore an opposing player and let Spelich double team or free lane. Spelich often guards the opponent's second-biggest player despite her ordinary stature.

Spelich takes care of details. She calls plays or pulls the team into a quick strategy huddle.

And Spelich plays hurt, wearing a back support for an injury she suffered late last season.

"Marci's great for us on defense," said Kaayla Chones, North's All-American center. "Her ability to call huddles, to get the team pumped up is very important."

"She's one of the better passers on the team. She's so unselfish and she opens up things for all of us, including herself, because she can shoot, too. Marci's attitude of team first is great."

Spelich was her team's leading scorer in middle school. Even then, her mother re-

members, Spelich would pass the ball to a reserve and yell, "Shoot."

"Passing, steals and defense are more important than my offense," Spelich said. "My coaches and teammates always comment, always recognize what I do."

"Coach Beutel and all of our coaches are very considerate. They always make sure that everything is OK with me."

Spelich simply likes to keep everybody involved. When she returns home after being out with friends, she makes a point to talk with her father, Mike, and her mother. She's close to her older sisters, Natalie, Carrie and Jamie.

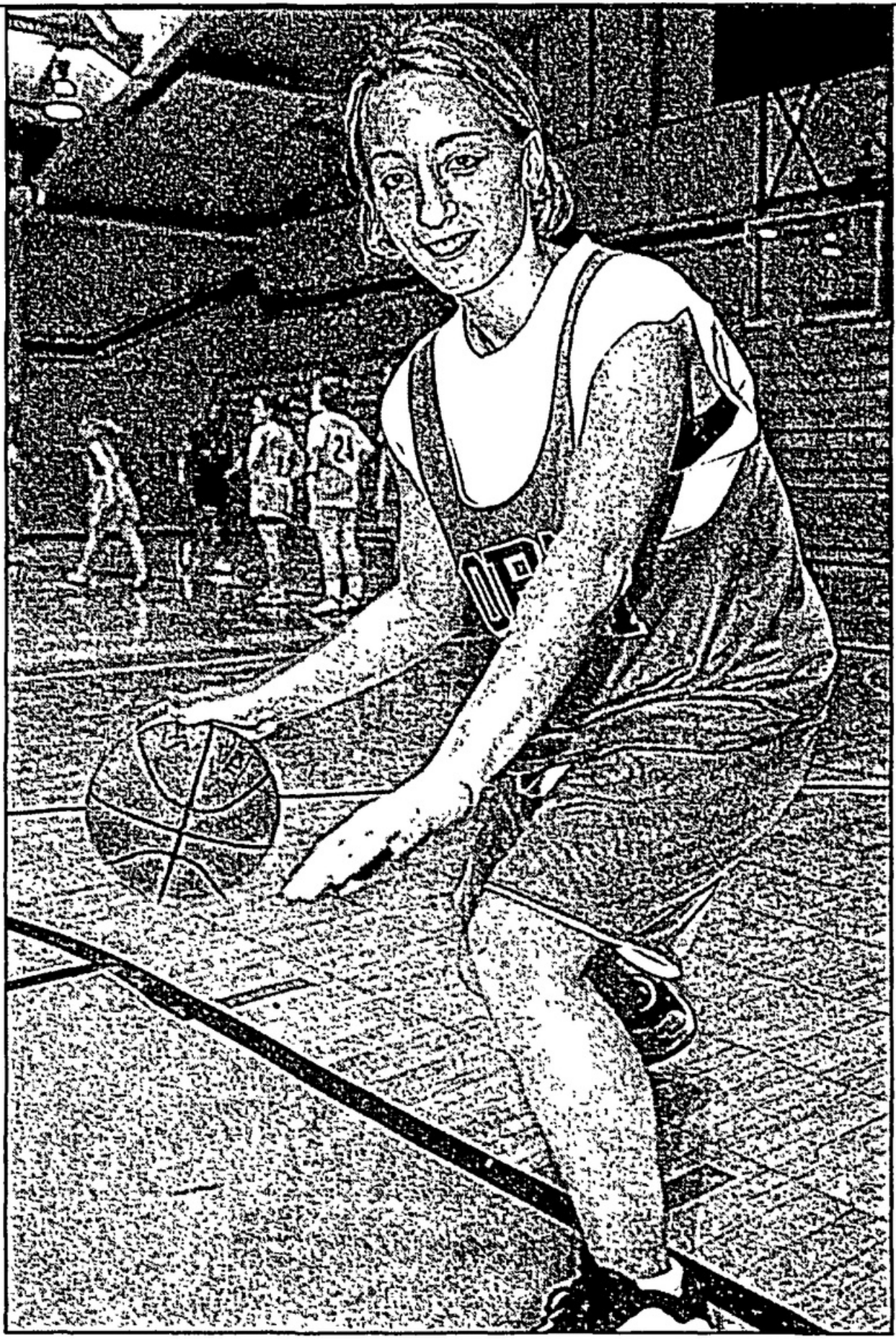
"I try to make sure everybody around me is OK," Marci Spelich said. "I'm very respectful to adults. I just try to make things easier on everybody and help out everybody."

Spelich's kindness, typical of her prototype point guard personality, extends beyond family and team. Last winter, she sent a note of thanks to The Plain Dealer after she was selected as a Player of the Week.

Nearly two years ago, Carrie gave Marci a birthday gift, a baseball autographed by Brian Anderson, the Geneva-native who had excelled for the Indians during the 1996 postseason. Later, Marci asked Carrie for permission to give the baseball to a North teacher, David Craig, for his birthday.

"Mr. Craig always talked to me about sports," Marci said, "and I knew he liked the Indians."

Little wonder that Marci Spelich would give somebody else her baseball. She's always passing around basketballs that could just as well be hers.



Guard Marci Spelich is always in position to pass to an Eastlake North teammate.

BY THE NUMBERS

BOYS BASKETBALL

YESTERDAY'S SCORES

Cleveland South 68, Collingwood 60
Eastlake 72, James P. 60
East Tech 66, Lincoln-West 58
Glenview 102, John Marshall 56
John Hay 84, Cleveland John F. Kennedy 56

Lake Erie Division

Cleveland Hills 90, Elyria 53
Eastlake 73, Lakewood 41
Shaker Hills 73, Mentor 65
Elyria 73, Lakewood 41
Bedford 102, Garfield 79
Maple Hills 86, Nondol 57
Shaw 56, Parma 51

East Suburban

Bedford 63, Bloomfield 39
Valley Forge 69, Berea 47
Amherst 65, Lorain 40
Buckeye 72, Avon Lake 50
Canton McKinley 74, Cleveland Falls 64
Rocky River 69, North Ridgeville 58
Nondol 56, Orange 51

Northwestern

Aurora 60, Independence 55
Chagrin Falls 67, Beachwood 59
Kent 67, West Geauga 61
Wickliffe 54, Mayfield 54
Hawken School 46, University School 46
Cleveland Hills 71, Elyria 53
Cleveland Heights 65, Lake Ridge 43
Maplewood 74, Vermilion 44
Jackson-McKee 57, Lorain 40
Jefferson Area 73, Leavittsburg 48

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